

II7 Zechariah and Elizabeth

An old priest and his wife who waited on God for years and became the parents of John the Baptist.

After the long years since Malachi, God speaks first to an ordinary priest and his wife, blameless in his sight, yet old and childless. While Zechariah served in the temple, the angel Gabriel promised them a son who would prepare the way for the Lord. Zechariah doubted and was struck silent. Elizabeth welcomed her relative Mary and called Mary's unborn child "my Lord." Theirs is a story of faithfulness in the long wait.

At a glance

Names	Zechariah, "the Lord has remembered"; KJV Zacharias, Elisabeth
Family	Priest of Abijah's course; she of "the daughters of Aaron" (Luke 1:5)
Son	John the Baptist (Luke 1:13, 57–63)
Relative	Mary, Elizabeth's "cousin," meaning kinswoman (Luke 1:36)
When	c. 7–4 BC, "in the days of Herod, the king of Judaea"
Key places	The temple; their home in the hill country of Judah (Luke 1:39)
Main passages	Luke 1:5–25, 39–80

"And they were both righteous before God, walking in all the commandments and ordinances of the Lord blameless."

Luke 1:6, KJV

The life of Zechariah and Elizabeth

Dates are approximate (BC). They depend on Jesus' birth, c. 6–4 BC, since John was about six months older.

c. 7–5 BC

Old age

● Chosen to burn incense

Zechariah's priestly division is on duty, and the lot falls to him to offer incense in the temple. The people pray outside while he stands alone before the altar of incense. *Luke 1:5–10*

c. 7–5 BC

In the temple

● Gabriel's promise

An angel says their prayer is heard: Elizabeth will bear a son named John, filled with the Holy Ghost, who will turn many to God. Zechariah asks for a sign and is struck mute. *Luke 1:11–23*

c. 7–5 BC

Five months

● Elizabeth conceives

Back home, Elizabeth becomes pregnant and keeps herself hidden for five months. She praises God for taking away her reproach among the people. *Luke 1:24–25*

c. 7–5 BC

Sixth month

● Mary's visit

Mary arrives from Nazareth. At her greeting the baby leaps in Elizabeth's womb, and Elizabeth, filled with the Holy Ghost, blesses Mary. Mary stays about three months. *Luke 1:36, 39–56*

c. 6–4 BC

Eighth day

● "His name is John."

Neighbours expect the boy to be named after his father. Elizabeth says he will be called John, and Zechariah writes the same on a tablet. His tongue is loosed at once. *Luke 1:57–64*

c. 6–4 BC

After the naming

● Zechariah's song

Filled with the Holy Ghost, Zechariah blesses God for redeeming his people and foretells that his son will go before the Lord to prepare his ways. *Luke 1:65–80*

Key activities

Luke gives no ages. He says only that both were "well stricken in years" (Luke 1:7). Scripture says nothing of them after John's birth.

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- 1 **Lived blameless lives.** Both walked in all God's commandments, even while their prayers for a child went unanswered. *Luke 1:6-7*
 - 2 **Served faithfully in the temple.** Zechariah went up to Jerusalem when his course was on duty and did the work given by lot. *Luke 1:8-10*
 - 3 **Prayed for years.** The angel's first words were that Zechariah's prayer had been heard. *Luke 1:13*
 - 4 **Doubted and was silenced.** Zechariah asked how he could know this, since he and his wife were old. He could not speak until the promise came true. *Luke 1:18-22*
 - 5 **Gave God the credit.** Elizabeth hid herself and said, "Thus hath the Lord dealt with me," for he had taken away her reproach. *Luke 1:24-25*
 - 6 **Blessed Mary.** Elizabeth cried out, "Blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the fruit of thy womb," and called Mary "the mother of my Lord." *Luke 1:41-45*
 - 7 **Obedied in naming John.** Both parents held to the name God gave, against family custom. *Luke 1:59-63*
 - 8 **Prophesied.** Zechariah's song, often called the Benedictus, praises God's mercy and calls John "the prophet of the Highest." *Luke 1:67-79*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name them. Tradition (Protevangelium of James, 2nd century, not Scripture): Zechariah was killed for hiding the infant John.

Old Testament

1 Chronicles 24:1-19	Twenty-four priestly courses; the eighth is Abijah's
Malachi 3:1; 4:5-6	The messenger and "Elijah," applied to their son
Echo: Genesis 18:9-14; 1 Samuel 1:1-20	Other childless couples given a son

New Testament

Luke 1:5-80	The only account of their lives
Luke 3:2	"John the son of Zacharias"
Matthew 23:35	"Zacharias son of Barachias," most think not John's father

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How does Luke describe Zechariah and Elizabeth before any miracle happens (Luke 1:6-7)?
2. *Understand:* Zechariah and Mary both asked the angel a question (Luke 1:18, 34). Why might one question lead to silence and the other not?
3. *Apply:* Elizabeth and Zechariah served God faithfully through years of unanswered prayer. What prayer have you been waiting on, and how do you keep serving meanwhile?
4. *Apply:* Elizabeth welcomed Mary and strengthened her faith. Who could you encourage this week, and how?